Qing Statesmen, Archivists, and Historians and the Question of Memory

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The great government book-collecting project of eighteenth-century China, the "Complete Library in Four Branches of Literature,"[1] offered the Qing government (1644-1912) an opportunity to proscribe and even destroy works it found offensive, particularly those that expressed antigovernment or anti-Qing sentiments. An imperial edict deputed high officials to supervise the burning of the works on the government's Index Expurgatorius at a site outside the capital city, Peking. After that, except for a remnant surviving in Japan or Europe, the presumption was that all copies of these works were permanently lost, just as the court had intended.

But the story has a happy ending: when the Qing archives were opened after the fall of the dynasty in 1912, the forbidden and supposedly destroyed books were found safely secreted inside the Grand Council archival vaults in the imperial palace. These works had survived because an unknown eighteenth-century hero—probably a high official with archive-supervisory responsibilities—defied the court's directive. He could not bear to destroy books. Apparently he was more concerned with memory than with obedience.[2]

A second story illustrates a similar archival impulse. In some Qing reports to the throne, the three characters for the name of Sun Yat-sen, the rebel leader who eventually rose to be extolled as the founding father of modern China, were disparaged by being written with a dog signific to the left of each character—a common form of derision (in our parlance, probably similar to calling someone "a dirty dog"). The repository, a Republic of China government organization, felt it had to prohibit such sacrilege—mocking the founder of the nation could not be allowed. I am told that the reports in question have been removed from the open collection and are now hidden away in the Taibei Palace Museum, available only by special permission.[3] Again, the evidence was not destroyed but secreted.

These stories allow us to see one of the driving principles behind Qing archival preservation—save everything. As demonstrated by the preservation of the forbidden books and the documents with the derogatory dog symbols, this imperative included saving items not necessarily in the government's interest. This has been fortunate for the cause of preserving social memory. Although the Qing government made very little effort to reach out into the society and collect what might be regarded as items of social memory, and although these did not survive well when left beyond the government's protection, if such items did reach the archives, there was little risk of discard or loss. Fortunately, the concept of pre-archivage—weeding out documents deemed of minimal interest before turning them over for storage—was not known to the archivists of Qing times.[4]

Yet another feature of the Qing archives illustrated by these stories was that many Chinese government archival installations—and there are very few private holdings—are pleasingly eclectic, with contents going far beyond the category of government documents. As in the tale of the eighteenth-century books saved from burning, Chinese archives may even preserve printed books.[5] In addition, artifacts (not just drawings of the artifacts, which are also preserved, but in some cases the artifacts themselves) were saved, as well as song-sheets, court circulars, and even a few private papers. Newspapers and other items we might not consider appropriately archival frequently turn up. A Chinese archive is likely to be a repository of Page 418 → a vast assortment of items. Anything may be held in its vaults.

A Chinese Definition of Social Memory?

In writing this essay, I have not found a clear definition of Chinese or even Qing "social memory" that might find favor with the archival profession. Because the discussion of memory has been a debate conducted primarily among historians in the West, their definitions do not precisely fit the Chinese case. Maurice Halbwachs, one of the earliest Western historians to grapple with the problem, drew his main distinction between "individual

memory" on the one hand and "collective" or "social memory" on the other.[6] Some analysts have found the two principal kinds of memory to be "private" and "public."[7] Two comparative historians discussing memories of twentieth-century wars in Japan, Germany, and the United States equate memory of the wars with the official versions that dominate news stories and textbooks and suggest that social memory is unofficial memory.[8] For the Chinese case, however, my own findings are quite different.[9]

From my study of archival practice in Qing times, I observe that Qing officials did not frame their discussions of archival practice in terms of individual and collective memories, nor did they employ any of the other Western dichotomies outlined above. Instead, they divided their holdings into two large groups of archived materials, one in the outer court *(waichao*), and one in the inner court *(neiting*). The first consisted of what the government wanted known, a form of memory that might be described as "managed," "authorized," or "official." Documents in this category expressed the state's version of events and were allowed to circulate in the vast, open, outer-court bureaucracy; eventually most of these came to be housed in the vaults of the Grand Secretariat Great Treasury (Neige daku). The second, for want of a better term, may be said to have consisted of "everything else"—official secrets, personnel evaluations, heterodox rebel confessions, unofficial materials, documents too cumbersome to circulate, miscellany, and the like.[10] These were held in the inner-court archives, chiefly in the Office of Military Archives (Fanglueguan [11] In this scheme, both outer- and inner-court materials could be official, but in addition, documents of social or unofficial memory might be deposited in both kinds of archival holdings.[12] In a broad sense, unofficial memory embraced all kinds of background information helpful in understanding both the official and the alternative or unofficial views. Much of that information would have been collected by Qing government personnel acting in their official capacities. Because of Qing archivists' laudable willingness to save almost everything, I tell my graduate students that they should not ignore the official archives even when collecting materials for studying the unofficial side of history, as well as local archives if those are appropriate.[13]

But what about nongovernment and nonofficial sources of information that were not held in government archives? Would these be fruitful sources of social memory? The answer is that they surely would be—but only if we can locate them, a dubious prospect indeed. During the Qing, little effort was made to preserve the unofficial or the private. Much has been lost. The reader may well ask why present-day archivists and historians in search of Qing social memory do not zealously scour the country for privately held collections of personal papers.[14] But aside from printed book collections, Qing policy discouraged families from holding on to such papers.

One eighteenth-century example of the court's accusation against an individual will suffice to demonstrate the dangers that might lurk in a private hoard. In the Yongzheng reign (1723-35), a government examination commissioner chose one of the topics from an ancient classical text—what we would call an essay question—with the subject, "Where the people rest" *(weimin suozhi*). The Yongzheng emperor, or someone in his entourage, looked at this quotation and observed that its first and last characters resembled those of the emperor's reign title (Yongzheng) but with a significant difference: in the quotation the tops of the characters resembling the reign-title characters "Yong" and "Zheng" were removed. By a tortured process of reasoning, the selected quotation was then viewed as recommending that the emperor have his own top—or head—lopped off. Indeed, in the eighteenth century this was assumed to be the motive behind the official's choice of examination question.

As a result, the hapless official was forthwith cast into prison, where he died. His male family members were also imprisoned and his widow consigned to internal exile.[15] The story of this official's fall became well known at the time and warned others against harboring anti-Qing sentiments—or at least against committing them to paper. Ridding one's home of anything that might some day be the object of a twisted interpretation and taken to be incriminating evidence of antigovernment views was a necessity in the face of an imperial paranoia so strong it Page 419 → could wreck an entire family. Although in China periods of official paranoia have alternated with occasional mild relaxations, in general it may be said that private papers and letters did not survive well. Few private and unpublished family or business papers from Qing times are today available for consultation.[16]

So for social memory from Qing times, the Chinese official archives must be our chief recourse. There, memories rising from the society take many forms. Although much evidence that we would eagerly read today never found its way into official archival storage, nevertheless, even a haphazard search of government archives may retrieve

valuable materials. One of the most obvious examples of social memory in the Qing archives is rebel confessions—these often describe the heterodox beliefs that inspired rebellions and identify the master-disciple networks that transmitted those beliefs throughout the countryside. Another example lies in the records of criminal cases preserved in the archives, which might also contain antigovernment anguish. Many officials sent in the information basic to social memory or essential for illuminating context when fulfilling reporting requirements on prices, weather, harvests, and earthquakes. I once came across an official provincial document that described a plague of grasshoppers, complete with an enclosed drawing of the nasty creatures' nests.[17] Such a report served an official purpose in the Qing and yet today can help us understand the unofficial.

It is probable that in the end, neither official nor unofficial memories can be preserved in all their fullness of detail—they are ideal types that cannot be fully assembled and grasped in all their diversity. In many instances it is more difficult to dredge up social memories than to become informed on the well-publicized and widely circulated official statements of government-managed memory. The retrieval and preservation of social or unofficial memory may be eased for archivists who assemble materials on the twentieth century, for which we have much more documentation in the form of newspapers, letters to newspaper and journal editors, historical movies, television programs, textbooks, personal reminiscences, oral histories, and interviews, almost none of which survive for the Qing.

A Manual of Qing Archival Policy

Let us imagine that the Qing statesmen, archivists, and historians in charge of supervising the archives were to compose a rule book of prescribed archival practice, particularly in relation to social memory. What prescriptions would such books contain? The Qing's high official supervisors were committed to upholding the approved views—in some situations they might even have determined what these should be. In what follows I have used both the archival supervisors' arrangements and storage methods as well as their occasional explanations of policy to pull together some of the advice and regulations they might have written had they composed an office training manual for instructing the next generation of archivists.[18]

In the imaginary guide, the primary aim of archival preservation would have been, of course, to protect the regime and allow no antigovernment views to circulate widely, even if inscribed in government documents. Next would have been the aim of preserving the imperial face. The emperor had to be portrayed in the best possible light: losses of the imperial temper or evidence of imperial incompetence or even of indecision had to be treated as national secrets. A tertiary consideration would have been to preserve the face of officials, provided that such did not conflict with the first or second aim. When the Yongzheng emperor, for instance, scathingly wrote to a local official, “You are just one of those mediocre provincial officials appointed on a trial basis because I could not find anyone better,” although this put the official in an unfavorable light, the document was allowed to circulate and even appear in print.[19] Supervising officials may have decided that the emperor's withering insight was more worthy of publication than any secret handling that might have been sensitive to the official's need for face. Or the official may not have possessed enough clout at court to prevent publicizing this stroke of imperial wit.

The archival supervisors' aims, if carried out, guaranteed a view of the government as all-powerful, effective, and orderly. The government was to be portrayed as offering thoroughgoing control from the center and organized to discourage challenges. Such an outlook offered little hope to those who championed alternative views—and of course that was precisely what was intended. On rare occasions an archivist might save some prohibited books or documents, but for the most part the archives were designed to preserve the government's story.

The chief curatorial method was to create a structure that accomplished the same thing as our classification systems—top secret, secret, and so forth. The Qing government achieved this with its two parallel but separate communication systems, one—the old open, outer-court *(waichao)*, nonsecret system inherited from the previous dynasty (the Ming)—and the secret one created in the early Qing that operated in the inner court *(neiting)*. Page 420 → The two systems possessed separate document streams, separate methods for processing the documents on their arrival at the capital, separate storage systems for archiving the documents, and separate systems for using documents to write official historical works.[20] This strict division had the advantage of compartmentalizing not

only the documents but also the personnel allowed to see them.

The two systems were not exactly alike. By mid-Qing times (the eighteenth century), the old outer-court system was a structure operated by a vast bureaucracy through which documents could circulate easily. This structure included methods for making selected documents available to the officials and in cases of certain public announcements to the population of the country at large. The best-known of the vehicles fulfilling this purpose was the *Peking Gazette* (*Tangbao*), a court circular that was regularly dispatched to government offices in the provinces to make selected documents widely available in a timely fashion. Many official historical works were also compiled from documents that circulated in the outer court.

The inner court possessed almost the same structure, but one in which access to its secret documents and facilities was limited to a small coterie of Grand Council high officials, clerks, errand runners, and other staff—possibly little more than two hundred men.[21] Accordingly, the inner court had its own document stream (the palace memorials),[22] its own processing offices (the Chancery of Memorials [Zoushichu] and the Grand Council), its own archive (the Office of Military Archives [Fan-glueguan], which actually contained much more than just military reports), and its own publications (chiefly the campaign histories [*fanglue*]).

But it was not a case of the left hand not knowing what the right hand was doing. The separation between the two systems was not rigid—there were crossovers. These were achieved not by bureaucratic regulations or traditional routines but personally, through the high supervising officials. By means of personal directives—sometimes emanating from a source as high as the emperor himself—documents could flow between the two courts, although the main direction was from the secrecy of inner-court storage to the openness of the outer court. As just about everything that came to hand was saved, the primary issue was not what to save but what to disseminate.

Having provided the background necessary to understand how the system might have been manipulated, I shall take up four principal methods of restricting or allowing circulation of documents as these developed over the course of the middle Qing (eighteenth and early nineteenth centuries): first, reducing opportunities for publication; second, direct action to arrange circulation; third, a secret enclosure system; and fourth, in some cases arranging that a report conveyed information needed to protect the government. The training manual that I have envisioned might well have described several more ruses for ensuring that the archives told the government's story rather than raising specters of social memory—but my four examples will suffice.

The earliest method that the imaginary rule-book might have treated was the reduction of opportunities for publishing archival documents. Toward the end of the Yongzheng period (1723-35), at a point when nearly all palace memorials, and indeed the entire system, were kept secret, the court decided to celebrate the accomplishments of the reign by publishing considerable numbers of edicts and reports to the throne.[23] The centerpiece of this publication effort was a printed edition of thousands of the emperor's own handwritten responses (vermilion rescripts) on the provincial palace memorials *(Yongzheng Zhupi yuzhi*), an enormous compilation that publicized the emperor's painstaking concern for government affairs.[24] In permitting such publications, high officials, archivists, and editors ruled out state secrets, concealed imperial weakness, and allowed certain officials to enjoy a high reputation because of their inclusion in a work sponsored by the throne.

In particular, the printing of the Yongzheng palace memorials offered an opportunity to use selected documents to display an active, effective government, headed by an emperor whose lengthy vermilion rescripts showed him to be devoted to duty. In the Yongzheng-period inner court, documents were packed for archival storage in three separate groups: “published” *(yilu*), “yet to be published [in a new edition that in the end was never undertaken]” *(weilu*), and “not to be published” *(bulu*). The final prohibited category concealed not only national secrets but also the emperor's and the officials' weaknesses—these also a kind of national secret. This final category is also a good place to look for evidence of unofficial memory.

For example, a report early in the reign from one of the Six Boards at the capital described the lamentable results of an examination to identify translators well versed in both Manchu and Chinese. When the results were graded, only 9 men of the 414 who originally took the test were deemed truly capable of accomplishing the desired translation work, while 116 individuals were rated only “ordinary” (*pingchang*). A large bottom group consisted

of 289 men who did not qualify at all— Page 421 → 47 of these had turned in totally blank test papers.[25] Such a dire state of translation proficiency would not have reflected well on the government. It was reasonable to suppress such a report.

Other secrets eliminated in the publication of the Yongzheng palace memorials suggest how desirable it may be to go through the list of prohibited items.[26] A proscribed report of YZ7 (1729) listed the “nourish-honesty” (*yanglian*) stipends then being paid to Gansu provincial officials.[27] Also prohibited were many staff memoranda written to suggest a recommendation or path of action for the emperor's consideration. Frequently Yongzheng would simply copy these with scarcely a change into his vermilion rescripts on the memorials, which would then be returned to the author so he would learn the imperial views. Such staff recommendations had to be concealed, lest the emperor appear incapable of framing the policies regularly attributed to him alone.[28] Often these memoranda dealt with the thorny details of government finance and are well worth examining today. In fact, I developed a habit of identifying the prohibited memorials in the files and scrutinizing them with especial care.[29]

Another midreign communication on military encampments was probably denied outer-court circulation because it revealed that at the highest levels in the inner court, the government had connived to deceive the outer court about the existence of the then-secret palace memorial system. The imperial calligraphy on this report begins with a recital of current regulations (doubtless known only in the inner court) for sending important information to the outer court without revealing the existence of the palace memorials: “What ought to be reported in a routine memorial [i.e., a report in the outer-court stream], accordingly report. It is not permitted because of [something in] a palace memorial not to send in a routine version.” But in the final section, after this lecture on regulations, the emperor suddenly reversed himself and concluded: “In this case, that temporarily need not be done.”[30] This confusing rescript may have been withheld because it showed the government in a thoroughly bad light, not only because of the conniving that produced duplicate reports—one for each communication system—but also because of the revelation of imperial indecision, qualities deemed unsuitable for publication.

An example of how officials' face was taken care of appears in a report from the end of the reign. Here, the emperor kept up his sarcastic needling on the subject of official inadequacies: “This memorial has much glossing, ” he wrote, “You [surely] did not read it over.”[31] What had probably happened was that the provincial governor-general had simply forwarded the local financial official's report without checking. The memorial was withheld from circulation, possibly because this official was highly regarded and as a result was given protection against unfavorable publicity. In fact, many candid personnel reports from the Yongzheng period were secreted lest the emperor's and the reporting official's comments should become widely known. In one exposition, a provincial memorialist described a subordinate as only ordinary, beside which the emperor exclaimed: “Yes” *(shi*). Later the emperor castigated another official with the statement, “I fear his sense of integrity needs looking into,” and agreed with the memorialist's frank assessment of a third as “scatterbrained” *(qingtiao*).[32] Revelation of such candid comments could have been extremely damaging to morale throughout the bureaucracy.

Another kind of tinkering with the archival record appears in documents purportedly published from archival originals. The published Yongzheng-period memorials exhibit curious differences between the archival originals and their published forms. When I compared about two hundred reports with their published versions, I found only five instances in which the published versions did *not* display differences. Some of the changes were utterly insignificant; nevertheless, researchers would like to be assured of verisimilitude. The eighteenth-century editors frequently condensed a provincial author's verbiage and even rewrote the emperor's comments. Apparently the editors sought to give the imperial writing an elevated tone. For instance, one published rescript had the emperor quoting the classical philosopher Mencius, but the archival original yields no imperial reference to the sage or his works.[33] This editorial strategy was intended to reinforce the image of deep classical learning as part of the public imperial persona.

Later in the eighteenth century, the system came to be manipulated in another way—which our imaginary guidebook of prescriptions might have described—when the palace memorials had become both more numerous and less secret. This was accomplished by having high supervising officials, or sometimes the emperor himself, determine which palace memorials would be released to the outer court. Release was a serious matter, because it

not only made the memorial content available to the many potential readers in the large outer-court bureaucracy, but also allowed the document contents to be included in the court circular *(Peking Gazette)* as well as more formal official publications. Reports thus fated Page 422 → would be ordered "turned over" *(jiao)* to the outer court.[34] Occasional imperial rescripts also prescribed release of memorial enclosures to the outer court with the formula "Also send the enclosure" *(dan bingfa*). In this way, large numbers of once secret palace memorials reached the outer-court bureaucracy. Our hypothetical manual would show that inaction easily preserved archival secrets—a special determination was needed to forward each individual memorial, and another to send on an enclosure.

A third kind of manipulation that may be observed in the middle to late eighteenth century was the practice of writing covering palace memorials that summarized situations but left the details—often significant details—to enclosures. The covering document—but not its enclosure—would then be released to the outer court. We know this practice had become prevalent by the end of the eighteenth century because it excited the imperial alarm, causing the Jiaqing emperor (r. 1796-1820) to caution officials against excessive use of what he called the "secret enclosure" (*jiapian*) system.[35]

How did the secret enclosure system work? Enclosure content was filled with what officials in the field had decided should be treated as unofficial memory. Frequently enclosures were written to convey details that might otherwise have clogged the narratives in the covering memorials—long lists of local crop and harvest conditions, for instance, food grain price levels, rain and weather facts, earthquake and flood reports, and maps. Another candidate for enclosure treatment was the confessions of captured rebels. Confession enclosures usually contained seditious information that had to be secretly stored in the inner-court archives and kept out of general circulation. Hundreds of such confessions, usually submitted as enclosures, today survive in one or two copies only from the late eighteenth and nineteenth centuries. They detail the organizations, beliefs, and hopes behind dozens of rebel groups all over China. Twenty-five years ago, a Yale graduate student, Susan Naquin (now teaching at Princeton), was the first to make substantial use of such documents, studying a set from an 1813 attack on the palace. Rebels were rounded up in and around Peking and extensively debriefed under Grand Council auspices, possibly with the use of torture. Naquin was able to tease out an entire book that for the first time in English or Chinese published a narrative and analysis of the nature of a Chinese sectarian rebellion.[36] Of course, the evidence of such sedition could not be permitted to circulate to the outer court, appear in the *Peking Gazette,* or be inscribed in the official historical works. Accordingly, today most confessions are still to be found in the secret inner-court archival holdings.

Archival materials can only be as good as the quality of information collected. A fourth kind of limitation that might have been prescribed in our imaginary manual involved restricting the kind of information collected in the first place. This practice met the larger goal of managing information so that it told the government's, rather than any other, story. For example, as it was thought desirable to protect officials, a report on a local uprising had to be composed to clear those involved of any and all dereliction of duty. The aim was to ensure that nothing damaging about the officials would be on file even in the top secret archives, and with high inner-court grandees supervising the taking of depositions, this was not difficult to arrange.

An example of this occurs in the Zhong Renjie case of 1841, when the captured leader was asked in the course of his interrogation if his uprising had been long in the planning. Of course, no rebel leader would be recorded as having answered such a question in the affirmative, lest the officials on the spot be accused of failing to uncover a rebellion in its planning stages. Zhong Renjie's confession complied very clearly with this requirement: "We were terrified and seized the town because we had killed an official, definitely not because we had plotted the rebellion beforehand." With this statement firmly incorporated in Zhong's deposition, the local officials (who may very well have been carrying out the initial interrogations) ensured that they would be off the hook. As a result, we shall never know if Zhong's small uprising really did erupt spontaneously, as the confessions piously attest, or was long-planned and carried out right under the noses of unobservant and lazy local officials.[37] In similar fashion, managed confessions might control other aspects of the reporting on an uprising. Much information we might like to have is forever lost, and the information that survives in the archives has to be interpreted in the light of the suspicion that some of it may have been noted to clear officials of blame rather than to determine facts.

Deliberate Forgetting

With the Qing archives so well managed and so much memory preserved, if not necessarily circulated, mention must be made of some of the few examples of deliberate official discard of documents. In these cases it apparently was not enough to bury an incriminating document in a Page 423 → secret holding—the document had to be destroyed. One instance concerns a missing archival record of an important imperial decision. In 1748, the grand councillor, Noqin, was sent to the southwest front to lead the Qing armies against the Jinchuan rebels. Unfortunately, Noqin was soon forced to admit defeat. When his reports of defeat reached the Qianlong emperor, Noqin was scheduled—without the formality of a trial—to be beheaded. To make matters worse, the sword of his brave grandfather, a hero of the Manchu conquest years, was hastily dispatched to the southwest to be employed in carrying out the execution, which was ordered to take place in full view of the assembled Qing armies.[38]

The archival record of this tale would surely make interesting reading, but one of the key pieces of evidence for the entire year of Noqin's demise, the “Record Book of [Grand Councillors'] Deliberations,” a compilation of probably several hundred pages, is missing.[39] What is more, the file was not lost *after* the fall of the Qing, when so many other palace relics were stolen by eunuchs—it has been missing at least since the first Grand Council archives inventory was compiled in the late eighteenth century.[40] This early disappearance of a potentially embarrassing record in contrast with very few other losses of Grand Council documents strongly suggests the use of that special archival oubliette—an archivist's purposeful destruction of a set of documents. In this case the proscribed topic was probably the terrible evidence and consequences of keen imperial frustration, disappointment, and even loss of temper.[41] For the Qing archivists, protecting the imperial face was the all-important goal.

Another deliberate example of archival forgetting that plagues our research today is the Grand Council archivists' failure to preserve the alternate position papers composed in response to the imperial order for a high-level deliberation.[42] In each instance, the final agreed-on position paper was copied for various files and preserved, but the alternatives appear to have been destroyed. This may have happened because of an unwritten “unanimity rule” to the effect that if the deliberating officials presented *one* unanimous position paper, the emperor was all but bound to accept it and did so in nearly every case. On the other hand, if the officials presented more than one position, the emperor was free to decide for himself. Bureaucratic solidarity could thus trump imperial will; bureaucratic disunity—and any surviving evidence of it—handed the decision-making power to the monarch.[43] Accordingly, to preserve an official dissent that had been registered along the way to final unanimity was to risk destroying the officials' opportunity to decide. There was no question but that records pertaining to dissent had to be destroyed.[44]

Conclusion

In relation to the Qing archives, social memory may be defined as a document-based remembrance different from or even in opposition to the official version of events. The government's authorized tales were the ones that circulated most freely. Nevertheless, with some crucial limitations, Qing government archivists also preserved many alternative views and accounts. This is a boon to present-day researchers because private papers do not survive well in China.

When using these materials, researchers must be aware of the nature of the limitations on Qing data collection—the poor survival rate of private papers, the management of reporting at the source, the special aims of archival collection and preservation, and the restrictions on circulation and publication. There were many such limitations—I have been able to describe only a few of the most notorious.

NOTES

In the notes below, the abbreviation TPM signifies documents in the Qing archive holdings of the Taibei Palace Museum. At the museum, a report to the throne may be retrieved by its assigned number; a document that has been published may usually be retrieved in the printed edition by its date. In the following notes, I supply this information, plus the name of each document's author.

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1. Chinese: Siku quanshu .
2. In the 1980s, an enterprising Taiwan publishing house printed the forbidden works.
3. I know this only as a story and do not claim to have inspected the reports themselves.
4. Had certain Grand Council documents been weeded, I might never have come across lists of tables of food ordered each day for the council, which I employed to estimate the number of staff members on duty there each day. See my *Monarchs Page 424 → and Ministers: The Grand Council in Mid-Ch'ing China, 1723–1820* (Berkeley: University of California Press, 1991), 172. The Grand Council archives also yielded other kinds of information that in different archival situations might have been discarded. On pre-archivage, see Guy Dubosq, *The Records Center: Idea and Instrument* (Washington: VIII International Congress on Archives, 1976). In contrast to weeding, occasional deliberate destruction of certain materials did take place, a subject I discuss later in this essay.
5. After the fall of the Qing dynasty (1912), many printed books, some from as early as the Song dynasty (960-1279), were also discovered in the Grand Secretariat archives.
6. Maurice Halbwachs, *The Collective Memory*, trans. Francis J. Ditter and Vida Yazdi Ditter (French edition, 1950; New York: Harper & Row, 1980), passim; see also Paul Connerton, *How Societies Remember* (French edition, 1950; New York: Cambridge University Press, 1989), 1 and passim.
7. For example, Charles S. Maier, *The Unmasterable Past: History, Holocaust, and German National Identity* (Cambridge, Mass.: Harvard University Press, 1988), 149.
8. Laura Hein and Mark Selden, “The Lessons of War, Global Power, and Social Change,” in Laura Hein and Mark Selden, eds., *Censoring History: Citizenship and Memory in Japan, Germany, and the United States* (Armonk, N.Y.: M. E. Sharpe, 2000), 3-50. Western historians of China have not dealt much with questions of memory, but when they do, the focus is usually on twentieth-century events such as the Nanjing Massacre and the Cultural Revolution. See, for example, Vera Schwarcz, “How to Make Time Real: From Intellectual History to Embodied Memory,” in Gail Hershatter et al., eds., *Remapping China: Fissures in Historical Terrain* (Stanford: Stanford University Press, 1996), 13-24, and Schwarcz's “The Burden of Memory: The Cultural Revolution and the Holocaust,” *China Information* 11, no. 1 (summer 1996): 1-12.
9. My focus on the Qing rather than archival policy through all of China's dynastic history is largely due to the fact that few original documents survive for dynasties before the Qing. For instance, about five thousand archival items survive for the Ming period (1368-1643), whereas the figure commonly given for Qing holdings is approximately 10 million items *(Qingzhu Zhongguo diyi lishi dang'anguan chengli liushi zhounian, 1925-1985* [Felicitations to the Number One Historical Archives of China on the sixtieth anniversary of its founding, 1925-1985] [Beijing, 1985], 9). Note that the latter is only a very general figure: it enumerates materials only at the Number One and does not differentiate between a single “item” of three lines and a six-hundred-page record book, also rated a single “item.” Yet the six-hundred-page album might contain as many as five hundred separate documents.
10. One kind of formal and not very descriptive personnel evaluation (the *kaoyudan*) was stored in the outer court.
11. Before the Qing inner-court system was developed, there was a way of holding secret documents in the outer-court vaults known as the Grand Secretariat Great Treasury (Neige daku). Such documents were specially labeled “secret” in the Great Treasury logbook, the “Record of Silken [i.e., imperial] Words” (*Silunbu*). Once the inner-court system was developed, however, the designation “secret” only rarely appeared in these outer-court logbooks.
12. I described the Qing outer and inner courts in *Monarchs and Ministers*, chap. 1 and passim. After the Kangxi reign (1661-1722), the inner-court repositories were generally used for documents that may be

described as consisting of unofficial memory.

13. Unfortunately, as a result of the civil wars that have beset China in recent centuries, local archives have survived much less well than those of the central government. Frequently a local archive's holdings date not from the beginning of the dynasty but only near the end, and even then contain only a few documents from before the twentieth century. For a highly useful bibliography of descriptions of the local archives of China, see Ye Wa and Joseph W. Esherick, comps., *Chinese Archives: An Introductory Guide* (Berkeley: University of California Institute for East Asian Studies, 1995).

14. In fact, in recent years Chinese archivists and historians have investigated old libraries and other holdings and have located a few lesser-known works.

15. L. Carrington Goodrich, “Cha Ssu-t'ing” (Ja Siting), in *Eminent Chinese of the Ch'ing Period* (Washington, D.C.: U.S. Government Printing Office, 1944), 22. The quotation comes from the Chinese classic, *The Great Learning* (chap. 3, 1). There is nothing in the original text to suggest sedition. See *The Chinese Classics*, trans. James Legge (reprint, Tabei: Wenxing Shudian, 1966), 1:362.

16. Even when government officials' private papers have been published, they rarely reveal confidential information of any kind. An example from my own research on the founding of the Qing Grand Council (the equivalent of a central government high privy council) is the autobiography of Zhang Tingyu, a Qing statesman closely involved in the council's founding and early growth. His autobiography reports hardly a word about the great event, and in some respects may be viewed as deliberately misleading, yet this key official certainly must have been well informed on the subject. See *Chenghuaiyuan zhuren ziding nianpu* [Chronological autobiography of [Zhang Tingyu]], 6 juan, preface dated 1749 (reprint, 2 vols., Taibei: Wenhai, 1970).

17. TPM, Palace Memorial YZ 016212 and enclosure, YZ2/8/7 (Sept. 23, 1724), Chen Shiguan. I am indebted to Professor Frederick W. Mote of Princeton University for identifying the depicted bugs as grasshoppers when I showed a slide of the document in the course of speaking at Princeton in 1979. Professor Mote assured me that plagues of grasshoppers as well as locusts do occur. The covering memorial has been published in *Gongzhongdang Yongzhengchao Zouzhe* [Palace memorials of the Yongzheng reign] (Taibei: Palace Museum, 1977), 3:24-26, but without its very interesting enclosure.

18. In fact, such booklets explaining some of the Qing government's archival practices are held in the Beijing Number One Historical Archives. Unfortunately, however, these guides are silent on many of the subjects of interest in this essay. Additional explanations most often appear in memoranda (*zou-pian*) addressed to the emperor and composed by high statesmen, archivists, and historians. By the early nineteenth century one such manual of prescriptions for Grand Council practice had been printed: *Shuyuan jilue* [Materials on Grand Council history], comp. Liang Zhangju (reprint, 2 vols., Taibei: Wenhai, 1967). The archives also contain earlier, unpublished rule books: see for example the record book held in the Beijing Page 425 → Number One Historical Archives, “Junjichu guizhu jizai” [Notations of Grand Council regulations] and TPM, “Junjichu wenyi dang” [Record book of Grand Council lateral communications [dispatched from the council's archives office]].

19. TPM, handwritten imperial rescript (excerpt) on the yellow summary (*tiehuang*) for Palace Memorial YZ 018965, YZ 7/10/28 (Dec. 18, 1729), Futai. The document was first circulated in the *Yongzheng Zhupi yuzhi* [Vermilion rescripts [and palace memorials] of the Yongzheng [emperor]], first appearing in an experimental edition printed in 1732.

20. For a table explaining these structures, see *Monarchs and Ministers*, 18-19.

21. Calculation from *Monarchs and Ministers*, 172.

22. “Memorial” is a nineteenth-century translation of the Chinese term for “report to the throne.”

23. Edicts first appeared in collections such as the “Yongzheng Shangyu Neige” [[Open] edicts to the Grand Secretariat] and “Baqi Shangyu” [Edicts to the Eight Banners].

24. On this work see my “The Secret Memorials of the Yung-cheng Period (1723-1735): Archival and Published Versions,” [Taibei] *National Palace Museum Bulletin* 9, no. 4 (Sept.-Oct. 1974).

25. TPM, Palace Memorial YZ 021955, YZ1/2/16 (Mar. 22, 1723), Board of Civil Office report. In fact, nearly all memorials from officials posted at the capital were put in the prohibited category. This memorial has recently been published in *Gongzhongdang Yongzhengchao Zouzhe* [Palace memorials of the Yongzheng reign] (Taibei: Palace Museum, 1977), 1:90. The emperor's Manchu rescript, omitted from this edition (this was the museum's editorial policy for all Manchu rescripts), stated that the 116 second-class

candidates should be sent for a further year of training to see if they might qualify.
26. When I made a close study of the Yongzheng government, I paid particular attention to the reports in the "prohibited" category. This can best be accomplished in the Taibei Palace Museum, whose card catalog provides this information as well as records of provenance for Yongzheng palace memorials. Long ago the Beijing Number One Historical Archives refiled its palace memorials according to eighteen large subject categories, a labor that also destroyed the documents' provenance.
27. TPM, Palace Memorial YZ 011817, undated, Xu Rong. The memorial can be dated approximately by examining the surrounding memorials in Xu Rong's archival packet, which bear the dates YC7/R7/9 (Sept.1, 1729) and YZ8/1/26 (Mar. 14, 1730).
28. See for example TPM, Palace Memorial YZ 019792, undated, Yinxiang and others, printed in *Gongzhongdang Yongzhengchao Zouzhe* 26:259. The imperial rescript that largely incorporated the high officials' recommendations appears in YZ 008880, YZ7/4/[no day] (1729), Yang Kun, and was published in the Palace Museum's Yongzheng palace memorials (13:102). The Taibei Palace Museum has many such pairs from the Yongzheng period. A different system for providing the emperor with advice was developed under the Qian-long emperor (r. 1736-95).
29. The Taibei Palace Museum's excellent memorial card files for the Yongzheng palace memorials include information on the publication status of each memorial—that is, their *yilu*, *weilu*, and *bulu* categorizations.
30. TPM, handwritten vermilion comment on Palace Memorial YZ 011573, YZ7/9/17 (Nov. 7, 1729), Maizhu. There are several such Yongzheng rescripts suggesting an imperial willingness to operate beyond regulations.
31. TPM, imperial marginalia on Palace Memorial YZ 011676, YZ13/7/15 (Sept. 1, 1735), Maizhu.
32. TPM, imperial marginalia on Palace Memorial YZ 011822, undated slip lacking author identification. It is reassuring to know that Yongzheng sometimes waxed enthusiastic about subordinates, as when he wrote in this same document of a circuit intendant: ". . . I can completely vouch for him. You must not be hard on him, he is someone who will work hard. Tell him what I have said."
33. TPM, Palace Memorial YZ 008020, YZ13/2/9 (Mar. 3, 1735). Publication of the circulated memorial cited here was in the *Yongzheng Zhupi yuzhi* (see n. 19).
34. A notation to this effect would have been inscribed in the inner-court logbook, picturesquely known as "Register for Keeping Up with Matters as They Come to Hand" [*Suishou dengji* . On this record book, see my "Ch'ing Documents in the National Palace Museum Archives: Document Registers: The Sui-shou tengchi," [Taibei] *National Palace Museum Bulletin* 10, no. 4 (Sept.-Oct. 1975).
35. *Jiaqing Shilu* 24/19a-20a, JQ2/11/24 (Jan. 10, 1798). Although only the word *jiapien* was employed, the rest of the passage shows that the enclosures of imperial concern contained secret information. There are other uses of the term *jiapian*.
36. See Susan Naquin, *Millenarian Rebellion in China: The Eight Trigrams Uprising of 1813* (New Haven: Yale University Press, 1976). See also Naquin's "True Confessions: Criminal Interrogations as Sources for Ch'ing History," [Taibei] *National Palace Museum Bulletin* 11, no. 1 (Mar.-Apr. 1976): 1-14 plus frontispiece. Confessions were not always handled uniformly. Some of this type of information arrived in the memorials themselves (*zhengben*), some in enclosures.
37. See Philip A. Kuhn and John K. Fairbank, with the assistance of Beatrice S. Bartlett and Chiang Yung-chen, *Reading Documents: The Rebellion of Chung Jen-chieh*, 2 vols. (Cambridge, Mass.: Harvard University John King Fairbank Center for East Asian Research, 1986; rev. ed., 1993), 17. I thank Professor Kuhn for this insight, which I first encountered when, as a postdoctoral fellow, I participated in his Qing documents class at Harvard in 1981-83.
38. Alfred Kühn, "Chang Kuangssu" (Zhang Guangsi), in *Eminent Chinese of the Ch'ing Period* (Washington, D.C.: U.S. Government Printing Office, 1944), 43-45.
39. This would be the *Yifu dang* for QL14 (1749).
40. See the Grand Council archival inventory (Beijing Number One Historical Archives #2258), "Han Junji dang'an zongce," passim. The last item inventoried is dated QL55 (1790), which suggests an inventory done in QL56 (1791), but the record also breaks in the middle with a last middle item of QL42 (1777), suggesting an inventory carried out in QL43 (1778).
41. Noqin was a distant imperial connection and had been a trusted member of the Grand Council, so the emperor may all the more keenly have despaired at the news of the military defeat.
42. These were known as "Memorials of Deliberation in Response [to the imperial order]" *(yifu zouzhe*).

Such Page 426 → discussions were usually carried out by grand councillors, but were sometimes done in conjunction with a board or other group.

43. There were some exceptions to this pattern, but the fact of the many imperial requests for *more* than one position certify that in the Yongzheng and for most of the Qianlong reign the unanimity rule prevailed. See an instance of the Yongzheng emperor's desperate attempt to divide his officials so that he might decide a case: “If [the deliberating officials] are unable to come to a unanimous position, there is no objection to [their producing] two recommendations, or three recommendations—all are permissible.” TPM, Palace Memorial YZ 020204, YZ2/6/8 (July 27, 1724), imperial rescript on the envelope of a Gao Chengling memorial. The issue here was the particularly vexing one of condemning men to death.

44. We know of other kinds of purposeful destruction of materials by Qing archivists. Sometimes when the storage vaults became too crowded, documents regarded as nonessential might be burned to make space for newcomers. This happened more in the Grand Secretariat than in the Grand Council archives. For an early example see *Gongzhongdang Kangxichao zouzhe* [Palace memorials of the Kangxi reign] (Taibei: Palace Museum, 1976), vol. 8, *Manwen yuzhi* [Manchu documents], 14-17, document of KX16/3/10 (April 21, 1677).